

4 Do your market research

The thing about running a business – especially a startup, is that it requires a whole lot of humility. The reason being the fact that you are bound to make mistakes, a LOT of mistakes.

Even the smartest of the smart Joes tend to screw up every now and then. They think that they can do no wrong and the idea that they have is amazing and foolproof. However, in the real world, they'll find that it's far from amazing. Almost always, the initial idea requires a fair amount of refining.

If you want your product to sell, you'll have to do some market research. You need to read the market, figure out what's selling and what isn't, see which demographic likes what, and apply that to your product. It all takes a fair amount of research and it's no walk in the park.

Say your idea is to start a company that's into T-Shirt printing. Now, when you say T-shirt printing to people, they're thinking "Well there's plenty of other brands that do the same thing, why should we come to you?". Now that is a very fair point they're



making. Add to that the fact that these brands might even be able to give the customer greater cost-advantage than you. But maybe you find that there's hardly any competition in printing T-shirts with messages which are exclusively expressive of the attitude of the office-crowd, such as the kind working in administrative jobs (don't take this seriously, it's just an example). By being the first, or among the first to pounce, you have created a viable niche for yourself. And that's the kind market research that will catapult you from being just another dime-a-dozen brand, to a unique one the people can't do without.

5 The Name

The naming of a brand is both a fun aspect as well as an extremely important aspect in the whole starting-a-business deal. Names which stand out gain a whole lot more attention in the market. The name is the first thing anyone will notice. It's as good as a first impression, and in the world of business a first impression is extremely impor-



tant as it can determine whether or not a customer will come back. Therefore, it is key that you opt for a name that will enable you to stand out and at the same time represent you and your business or company. When it comes to naming, try not to sound too similar to already existing names, or try not to mooch off of the success of already successful companies and call yourself something like foogle or Macebook, which probably already exist. At the same time, try not to make it too long, or a mouthful for someone to say, you want a name that is easy to say so that people can spread the word!

6 The marketing strategies

Unless your business idea is as fresh and unique as, say, teleportation, you are definitely going to devote a fair amount of attention to marketing. The good news is that you can build a good customer base without spending too much money if you are savvy enough. The bad news is that getting savvy about marketing isn't exactly easy.

For one thing, it involves learning and getting accustomed to the plethora of social platforms and other online avenues where people hang out – even the ones that you don't use or haven't even heard of. Then, there's the matter of knowing how to push relevant content to the prospective customer without being intrusive. Of course, you needn't be an expert about all these things yourself. You can hire a good marketing manager. But the thing is, marketing is very significant



when it comes to startups, and the insane number of startups has given rise to clutter in the market place. It's better to have at least an overall understanding of the scenario. If you aren't careful, the marketing budget will skyrocket without you getting the results you need to justify the costs.